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Profile

Assistant Professor at the University of Tehran and Director of the LLM Lab at TeIAS. Former Senior Researcher at Microsoft Research Montreal. Researcher in NLP and large language models, with a focus on interpretability, reasoning, multilinguality, cultural grounding, and creativity. Publications in ACL, NAACL, EMNLP, EACL, COLING, JAIR, TACL, TMLR, and Machine Learning. Senior Area Chair for ACL 2025 and ACL 2026.

Work Experiences

- **University of Tehran** — Tehran, Iran
  Assistant Professor, Electrical and Computer Engineering Faculty — *Dec. 2020 - Now*
- **Tehran Institute for Advanced Studies (TEIAS)** — Tehran, Iran
  Director of the LLM lab — *June 2024 - Now*
- **Microsoft Research** — Montreal, Quebec, Canada
  Senior Researcher in NLP and Deep Learning — *Nov. 2017 - Apr. 2021*
- **FANAP** — Tehran, Iran
  Software Developer — *Jun. 2010 - Jul. 2013*

University Educations

- **LMU Munich** — Munich, Germany
  PhD in Natural Language Processing (NLP) — *Feb. 2014 - Sep. 2017*
  - Dissertation grade: magna cum laude
- **Sharif University of Technology** — Tehran, Iran
  MSc. in Computer Engineering — *Sep. 2010 - Jan. 2013*
- **University of Tehran** — Tehran, Iran
  BSc. in Computer Engineering — *Sep. 2006 - Aug. 2010*

Selected Publications

- Synthia: Scalable Grounded Persona Generation from Social Media Data, *ACL 2026*, long paper.
- FFE-Hallu: Hallucinations in Fixed Figurative Expressions: Benchmark of Idioms and Proverbs in Persian, *EACL 2026*, long paper.
- Evaluating the Creativity of LLMs in Persian Literary Text Generation, *EMNLP 2025 Findings*, long paper.
- Evaluating Cultural Knowledge and Reasoning in LLMs Through Persian Allusions, *EMNLP 2025 Findings*, long paper.
- GenKnowSub: Improving Modularity and Reusability of LLMs through General Knowledge Subtraction, *ACL 2025*, short paper.
- Large Language Models for Persian-English Idiom Translation, *NAACL 2025*, long paper.
- PerCul: A Story-Driven Cultural Evaluation of LLMs in Persian, *NAACL 2025*, long paper.
- Comparative Study of Multilingual Idioms and Similes in Large Language Models, *COLING 2025*, long paper.

- DecompX: Explaining Transformers Decisions by Propagating Token Decomposition, *ACL 2023*, long paper.
- Looking at the Overlooked: An Analysis on the Word-Overlap Bias in Natural Language Inference, *EMNLP 2022*, long paper.
- Metaphors in Pre-Trained Language Models: Probing and Generalization Across Datasets and Languages, *ACL 2022*, long paper.
- GlobEnc: Quantifying Global Token Attribution by Incorporating the Whole Encoder Layer in Transformers, *NAACL 2022*, long paper.
- Increasing Robustness to Spurious Correlations using Forgettable Examples, *EACL 2021*, long paper.
- Probing for Semantic Classes: Diagnosing the Meaning Content of Word Embeddings, *ACL 2019*, long paper.
- Intrinsic Subspace Evaluation of Word Embedding Representations, *ACL 2016*, long paper.
- Corpus-level Fine-grained Entity Typing Using Contextual Information, *EMNLP 2015*, long paper.
- Corpus-level Fine-grained Entity Typing, *Journal of Artificial Intelligence Research*, 2018.
- ParsiNLU: A Suite of Language Understanding Challenges for Persian, *TACL*, 2020.
- Beyond the Imitation Game: Quantifying and Extrapolating the Capabilities of Language Models, *TMLR*, 2023.
- Persian Offensive Language Detection, *Machine Learning*, 2024.

Supervision and Leadership

- Director of the LLM Lab at TeIAS, leading research on large language models, interpretability, creativity, multilinguality, and cultural grounding.
- Supervised/co-supervised more than 10 MSc students; currently supervising MSc and PhD students working on NLP and LLM research.

Honors & Awards

- 2023: Dr Ashtiani's Award from Iran's National Elites Foundation.
- 2018: Recognition (an area chair favorite) from COLING 2018 conference for the paper "Recurrent One-Hop Predictions for Reasoning over Knowledge Graphs"
- 2010: Ranked 25th in National Entrance Exam for MSc. Studies in Computer Engineering, with nearly 8'000 participants
- 2006: Top 0.2% of the Nationwide University Entrance Exam in Physics and Mathematics, with nearly 323,000 participants

Professional Activities

- Senior area chair for ACL 2025 and ACL 2026.
- Area chair for ARR 2024, 2025, 2026.
- Area chair for Lexical Semantics track at ACL 2021.
- Remote presentation co-chair at ACL 2021.

- Organizing the 2nd version of SCLeM (Subword and Character Level Models in NLP) workshop at NAACL 2018, New Orleans, USA.
- Organizing SCLeM (Subword and Caracter LEvel Models in NLP) workshop at EMNLP 2017, Copenhagen, Denmark, Sep. 2017.
- Program committee of ACL, EMNLP, AAAI, EACL, NAACL, COLING, CIKM, LREC, Rep4NLP.

Teaching Experiences

- **Artificial Intelligence** — Instructor
  University of Tehran — *2021-2025*
- **Natural Language Processing** — Co-instructor
  University of Tehran — *2021-2022, 2026*
- **Foundation Models in Natural Language Processing** — Instructor
  University of Tehran — *2022-2023*
- **Large Language Models** — Co-instructor
  University of Tehran and TEIAS — *2024-2026*
- **Introduction to Data Science** — Co-instructor
  University of Tehran — *2024-2026*